# UNIT V - LISTENING SKILLS AND NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Communication has two sides: sending a message and receiving it. Listening is the skill of receiving spoken messages, and non-verbal communication is the message we send without words. Both are essential for a good speaker.

## 1. Importance of Listening

Listening takes up a larger share of our communication time than speaking, reading or writing. Yet many people never learn to listen well. **Hearing** is the physical ability to perceive sound; **listening** is the active mental effort to understand its meaning.

### Why listening is important

- **Learning:** most classroom information comes through listening.
- **Understanding instructions** correctly and avoiding mistakes.
- **Building relationships:** people trust those who listen to them.
- **Better speaking:** listening to good speakers improves your pronunciation, vocabulary and fluency.
- **Solving problems and avoiding conflict** because you get the full picture.
- **Career success:** managers, teachers, doctors and customer-service staff all rely on listening.

## 2. Basics of Listening

### The listening process

Listening works in five stages: **receiving** (hearing and paying attention), **understanding** (finding meaning), **remembering** (storing the message), **evaluating** (judging the message), and **responding** (giving feedback by words or actions).

### Types of listening

| Type | Purpose | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Appreciative | For enjoyment | Listening to music, a story or a poem |
| Informational | To learn information | Listening to a lecture or news |
| Critical (evaluative) | To judge an argument | Listening to a debate or advertisement |
| Empathetic | To understand feelings and support | Listening to a friend with a problem |
| Discriminative | To notice differences in sounds | Listening to pronunciation of /ship/ and /sheep/ |

### Active listening: how to do it

- Give full attention: look at the speaker and put away distractions such as your phone.
- Do not interrupt; let the speaker finish.
- Show interest through nods, a pleasant expression and small responses: 'I see', 'Go on'.
- Ask questions to clarify: 'Do you mean that...?'
- Paraphrase to check understanding: 'So you are saying that...'
- Take brief notes of key points when listening to a lecture.
- Do not judge or plan your reply too early.

## 3. Barriers to Listening

A barrier is anything that blocks the message from reaching the listener or being understood correctly.

| Barrier | Examples | How to overcome |
|---|---|---|
| Physical | Noise, poor acoustics, a bad phone line, hunger, tiredness | Choose a quiet place, sit near the speaker, rest well |
| Psychological | Stress, anger, worry, prejudice, fixed opinions, lack of interest | Calm yourself, keep an open mind, focus on the message |
| Language | Unfamiliar words, technical terms, strong accent, fast speech | Build vocabulary, ask the speaker to repeat or slow down |
| Attention | Daydreaming, thinking about your reply, using your phone | Concentrate and avoid multitasking |
| Information overload | Too much information at once | Take notes, ask for breaks |
| Cultural | Different customs and meanings of gestures | Learn about other cultures; do not assume |
| Speaker-related | Unclear, disorganised or boring delivery | Listen for the main points; ask questions |

## 4. Listening for Gist, Style and Tone

### Gist

The **gist** is the main idea or general meaning of a message. To listen for gist, ignore small details and ask: *What is this mainly about? What is the speaker's main point?* Listen to the opening and closing sentences, repeated ideas and words stressed by the speaker.

### Style

**Style** is the way language is used: formal or informal, simple or technical, spoken or written style, polite or direct. A lecture uses a formal, organised style; a chat between friends uses slang and short forms. Noticing style tells you about the speaker, the audience and the situation.

### Tone

**Tone** is the speaker's attitude or feeling, shown by pitch, speed, volume, stress and pauses. Words such as 'Fine' can sound happy, angry or sarcastic depending on the tone.

| Tone | How it sounds | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Cheerful | High pitch, lively pace | 'What a wonderful surprise!' |
| Angry | Loud, sharp, fast | 'I told you not to do that!' |
| Sad | Low, slow, soft | 'I miss him so much.' |
| Sarcastic | Exaggerated stress, flat or mocking voice | 'Oh, great. Another Monday.' |
| Polite / formal | Calm, even, careful words | 'Would you kindly help me?' |
| Neutral | Even, without strong feeling | 'The meeting is at five.' |

## 5. Voice Recording Exercises

Recording your own voice and other voices is a simple, effective way to improve listening and speaking.

- **Record yourself** reading a short passage or speaking for one to two minutes on a topic.
- **Play it back** and check pronunciation, stress and intonation, speed, pauses, volume, clarity and filler words.
- **Compare** with a model recording of a good speaker.
- **Repeat** after practice and note the improvement.
- **Listening tasks:** listen to a recorded talk or news item, write its gist in two sentences, then list three details.
- **Dictation:** listen and write down what you hear; then check against the script.
- **Group exercise:** record a conversation or role play and discuss how each speaker sounded.

## 6. Body Language

**Non-verbal communication** means sending messages without words, through the body, face, voice and use of space. **Body language** is the part of it that uses the body: gestures, posture, facial expressions, eye movement and touch. Researchers often say that a large share of the impact of a message, especially of feelings and attitudes, comes from non-verbal signals. People trust body language more than words when the two do not match.

**Forms of non-verbal communication**

| Form | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Kinesics | Body movement: gestures, posture, facial expressions | Nodding, shrugging, smiling |
| Oculesics | Eye contact and eye movement | Looking at the speaker to show attention |
| Proxemics | Use of space and distance | Standing close to friends, farther from strangers |
| Haptics | Touch | A handshake, a pat on the back |
| Paralanguage | How something is said: pitch, volume, speed, pauses | Speaking softly to comfort |
| Appearance | Dress, grooming | Formal clothes in an interview |
| Chronemics | Use of time | Arriving on time shows respect |

## 7. Importance of Body Language in Communication

- **Reinforces** words: nodding while saying 'yes'.
- **Replaces** words: a thumbs-up for 'good'.
- **Contradicts** words: saying 'I'm fine' with a sad face.
- **Regulates** conversation: looking at someone shows it is their turn to speak.
- **Shows feelings** and attitude: confidence, interest, nervousness or boredom.
- **Creates impressions** in interviews, presentations and meetings.
- Make your words and body language **match** so that you sound sincere and credible.

## 8. Gestures, Posture, Eye Contact and Facial Expressions

### Gestures

Gestures are movements of the hands, arms and head. They emphasise points and add interest.

- Use natural, open hand movements at about waist-to-chest level.
- Avoid distracting habits: fidgeting, tapping, playing with a pen or hair, pointing a finger at people.
- Be aware that gestures differ among cultures. For example, a nod means 'yes' in many countries, but a side-to-side head wobble in India can also mean agreement.

### Posture

Posture is the way you stand or sit. It shows confidence, energy and respect.

- Stand straight with shoulders relaxed and weight even on both feet.
- Sit upright, slightly forward to show interest; keep feet flat on the floor.
- Avoid slouching, crossing arms tightly (looks defensive), or leaning on walls and tables.
- Keep your hands visible and relaxed, not in pockets.

### Eye contact

Eye contact shows honesty, confidence and attention. A speaker who avoids eye contact may seem nervous or dishonest.

- Look at the person for a few seconds at a time, then look away naturally; do not stare.
- In a group or audience, move your gaze across all sections of the room.
- In some cultures, long direct eye contact with elders is considered disrespectful; adjust to the situation.

### Facial expressions

The face is the most expressive part of the body. Expressions of happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise and disgust are understood almost everywhere.

- A genuine smile creates warmth and trust.
- Let your expression match your words: serious for serious matters, pleasant for greetings.
- Avoid a blank or frowning face while listening, because it may look like boredom or disapproval.

| Body language | Positive signal | Negative signal |
|---|---|---|
| Posture | Upright, relaxed | Slouched, stiff |
| Eye contact | Natural, steady | Avoiding or staring |
| Hands | Open palms, calm gestures | Fidgeting, clenched fists |
| Face | Smile, interest | Frown, blank look |
| Arms | Relaxed at sides | Tightly crossed |
| Head | Nodding in agreement | Looking away, shaking head repeatedly |

## 9. Etiquette

**Etiquette** means accepted rules of polite and respectful behaviour in social, academic and professional situations. Good etiquette builds trust and creates a good impression.

### General etiquette

- Be **punctual**: arrive on time for classes, meetings and appointments.
- Dress suitably for the occasion; be neat and clean.
- Greet people politely and use 'please', 'thank you', 'excuse me' and 'sorry'.
- Do not interrupt; wait for your turn to speak.
- Show respect to elders, teachers and colleagues, regardless of their position.

- Respect different cultures, languages and beliefs.
- Keep your mobile phone on silent and avoid using it during conversations and meetings.

**Telephone etiquette**

- Answer promptly; greet and identify yourself: 'Good morning, this is Ravi speaking.'
- Speak clearly, in a pleasant tone and at a moderate speed.
- Listen carefully; do not eat or talk to others while on the call.
- End politely: 'Thank you for calling. Goodbye.'

**Meeting and classroom etiquette**

- Arrive before the starting time and switch off your phone.
- Raise your hand to speak and stay on topic.
- Listen to others without interruptions.
- Disagree politely and accept feedback gracefully.

**Dining and social etiquette**

- Wait for the host or elders before starting to eat.
- Do not talk with your mouth full.
- Thank the host.

## Recommended Reading


- Balan, K.R. and Rayudu, C.S. *Effective Communication*. Beacon, 1996.
- Howard, Peter. *Perfect Your Punctuation*. Orient Longman, Delhi, 1997.
- Lewis, Norman. *Word Power Made Easy*. Penguin Publishers, 2015.
- McCarthy, Michael and Felicity O'Dell. *English Vocabulary in Use: Advanced*. Cambridge University Press, 2008.
- Mohan Krishna and Banerji, Meera. *Developing Communication Skills*. Macmillan, 1990.
- Quirk, Randolph and Greenbaum, Sidney. *A University Grammar of English*. Longman, 1973.
- Wren, P.C. and Martin, H. *High School English Grammar and Composition*. Blackie Books, 2011.